

while excluding many instances of “ethical” activities. Let us clarify this with an example:

Imagine someone buys a game. This person has spent money purchasing this game legally, and would like to enjoy the same. However, the gaming experience is continually hampered by the DRM (Digital Rights Management) system which the game uses. The gamer is expected to be continually connected to the internet while playing the game, even though the internet connection is not required for gameplay. His poor connection quality means he will never be able to enjoy the game fully. What if this person then uses his computer skills to subvert the DRM system and play the game directly?

Would this instance of hacking be ethical? It certainly won't be legal. Who is this person harming here? Since this person has already paid for the game, and the game company isn't losing any money the only reason this is illegal is because the law says so, and the law seems to have been crafted with the content creator's interests in mind, not the consumer's. While some may disagree, we shall go ahead and rule this ethical.

The popular meaning of the term “ethical hacker” and the meaning you should derive from it whenever you hear it has to do with computer security – a field where the term ethical is more significant than hacker. In terms of computer security, an ethical hacker is a penetration tester, someone who tries to find vulnerabilities in a system in order to fix them, rather than to profit from exploiting them.

With computer security come two more terms, “White hat hackers” and “Black hat hackers”. These terms derive from old western films, where the villains were usually portrayed as wearing black hats, while the heroes wore white coloured hats.

White hat hackers are those who search for exploits and vulnerabilities in order to fix them, and stop others from being able to hack the system. They do not use their skills in order to harm others or for illegal activities. They are usually hired as security experts.

Black hat hackers are on the other hand, those who hack into systems for malicious reasons, in order to damage and deface web sites, steal passwords, or credit cards. They may do so in order to seek a profit, or out of pure malice. In a perfect world, they would be found in prisons.

There's always a middle ground; that place between black and white where most people live. Grey hat hackers are those who fall in this zone of ambivalent motives. They are those who cannot clearly be placed into the white hat or black hat categories.

As we said before, your ethics are your own, however if you want a career in computer security, your organisation is going to want to be sure that you will not be stealing their money or defacing their web site. There is as much career for a black hat as there is for a professional art thief.